markets rather than the developing markets', to compel the improvement of the quality of the products.

The export policy also aimed to decrease the company's geographical spread. Ratan advocated focused growth in select markets to ensure that the company would be able to invest in distribution and get a 'presence in that market', as opposed to exporting small numbers to various countries where it would not be economically feasible for the company to 'stand by them [the customers], support those vehicles in any way'.

Ratan was also unhappy with the company circumscribing itself by just preserving its market share in the commercial vehicles segment. Since the time he became chairman, he assiduously worked to increase its market share. He aimed to achieve this by leveraging the company's 'position as an integrated manufacturer'.

In 1997, he got the company to embark on an ambitious Business Process Reengineering Initiative, famously known as Project Top Gear. He foresaw the problems that the company might face in the future and took remedial action. As a consequence, it 'survived' and became 'stronger', K.C. Girotra, who retired as the vice president of Tata Motors, Lucknow region, says. Project Top Gear was implemented in Jamshedpur and Lucknow in 1998. It involved detailed reviews of 'design, development, strategic planning, manufacturing, sales, marketing and service, HR across three plants, dealers and service centres and performance review'. With the help of Andersen Consulting, the programme laid the foundation for a 'ready-to-change organization'.

Ratan also surprised the automobile industry by announcing that by 1997–98, TELCO would have an indigenously developed passenger car. The idea was to provide a car that would not be 'adapted' as the Maruti Suzuki cars were. It would be 'designed for India'. His aim was to have an Indian-designed car for Indians that the country could call its own. Ratan said that Japanese cars did not have the 'durability for the Indian roads' as they were 'designed for a different set of circumstances'. When compared to the Maruti 800, the Tata car would also be bigger and designed to be comfortable as a chauffeured car. Ratan also added that it would be economical, fuel-efficient and 'have the economies that a small car like the Maruti has'.

By the mid-1990s, TELCO's numbers showed significant improvement. Two years since Ratan had declared his aim to make TELCO a Rs 20,000